Ian Salon Booking App

INF353H – Information

Design Studio III: Designing Interactive Systems

Assignment #3

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Date: Saturday April 18th, 2026

Project Title: Ian Salon Booking App

Secondary Research

To support the design of this mobile hair appointment system, three sources were reviewed: the Fresha booking flow used by GOA Hair Salon Wellesley, Booksy's customer booking system, and Apple's Human Interface Guidelines. Together, these sources helped identify both service-specific booking patterns and broader mobile interface principles. Fresha was useful because it shows a real salon booking flow used in Toronto, while Booksy provided a stronger reference for appointment management after booking. Apple's Human Interface Guidelines were used to support interface decisions for iPhone-based interaction design.

The Fresha booking flow was especially helpful for understanding how salon services are structured and presented during booking. In the GOA Hair Salon Wellesley flow, users begin by choosing a booking type, then move through service categories, select one or more services, choose a professional or no preference, pick a date and time, and finally review the appointment before confirming. The system also shows important details such as service duration, price, salon rating, location, and cancellation policy before the final confirmation step. This makes the process transparent and gives users multiple chances to review their choices before committing (Fresha, n.d.).

A major strength of the Fresha flow is that it supports clear decision-making through step-by-step selection. Service categories are separated, prices and durations are shown early, and the review screen combines practical information in one place. The flow also gives users flexibility by allowing them to select a specific professional or choose no preference for greater availability. At the same time, the interface can become visually dense because long service lists and category switching require a large amount of scrolling. For first-time users, the number of options and add-ons may increase cognitive load, especially if they are not already familiar with salon terminology. This suggests that the new design should keep service selection clear, but reduce clutter and make key choices easier to scan.

Booksy was useful as a second reference because it focuses more clearly on ongoing appointment management. According to Booksy, clients can view past and upcoming appointments, reschedule themselves, track appointments, add bookings to their personal calendars, and pay through the app. Booksy also states that clients can cancel or reschedule appointments from their accounts, while providers may limit rescheduling based on cancellation policies. These features are especially relevant because they show how a salon

booking system should continue supporting the user after the initial booking is complete, rather than treating confirmation as the end of the experience (Booksy, n.d.-a; Booksy, n.d.-b).

This was an important finding for the current project because appointment management was one of the weaker areas in the previous design. Booksy provides a stronger model for how returning users can interact with an existing booking. Instead of only confirming an appointment, the system should also help users manage changes easily, including rescheduling, cancellation, and checking future bookings. This supports a more realistic user experience because plans change, and users often judge a booking system not only by how easy it is to book, but also by how easy it is to fix or change something later.

Apple's Human Interface Guidelines were used as a design guidance source for the mobile interface itself. Apple states that the Human Interface Guidelines provide guidance and best practices for designing experiences on Apple platforms. Several parts of the guidelines are especially relevant here. Apple describes text fields as appropriate for entering small, specific pieces of information, sheets as useful for focused tasks that are completed before returning to a parent view, and lists as helpful for presenting related items in a scannable way. These principles are directly connected to a hair appointment system, where users need to move through short steps, make clear choices, and review information without losing their sense of place in the flow (Apple Developer, n.d.-a; Apple Developer, n.d.-b; Apple Developer, n.d.-c; Apple Developer, n.d.-d).

These sources led to several design directions for the proposed system. First, the booking flow should be divided into short, manageable steps rather than showing too many choices at once. Second, service price, duration, and cancellation policy should be visible before confirmation so users can make informed decisions. Third, the system should support both first-time and returning clients by including profile creation, preferred stylist selection, and an easy appointment management flow. Finally, edge cases should be handled with clear feedback and actionable next steps, such as showing the next available date when a selected day is fully booked or explaining when a cancellation falls outside the allowed policy window. Overall, the secondary research suggests that a strong salon booking app needs both efficient booking and flexible post-booking support, while also following clear and readable mobile interaction patterns.

References

Apple Developer. (n.d.-a). *Human Interface Guidelines*. Apple.

Apple Developer. (n.d.-b). *Text fields*. Apple.

Apple Developer. (n.d.-c). *Sheets*. Apple.

Apple Developer. (n.d.-d). *Lists and tables*. Apple.

Booksy. (n.d.-a). *Customer app: Booksy for Customers*.

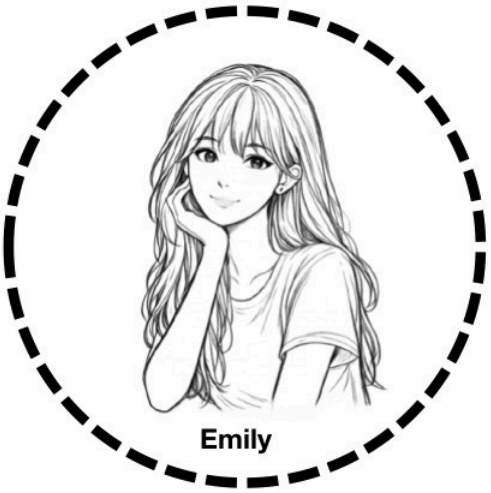
Booksy. (n.d.-b). *Can my clients cancel or reschedule an appointment at any time*.

Fresha. (n.d.). *GOA Hair Salon Wellesley - 593 Yonge Street Unit 3*.

Design Pitch

This project proposes a mobile hair appointment system for both first-time and returning salon clients. Existing booking flows provide useful step-by-step structures, but they can still become visually dense, require too much scrolling, and place more emphasis on initial booking than on managing appointments afterward. This design responds to those issues by breaking the process into shorter and more readable steps, showing service price and duration earlier, supporting both preferred stylist and no-preference booking paths, and making appointment management easier on mobile. The system includes new client registration, service and stylist selection, booking confirmation, and appointment management features such as rescheduling and cancellation. The goal of the design is to reduce uncertainty, lower cognitive load, and create a clearer and more flexible booking experience for users who want to make or manage salon appointments quickly on their phones.

Proto-Persona



Emily

22-year-old university student
Uses her phone to book salon appointments around classes and part-time work

Wants one smooth appointment for hair colour, haircut, and treatment without confusion

- Lives in downtown Toronto
- University student with a busy and changing weekly schedule
- Uses an iPhone for most daily tasks, including booking and messaging
- Usually books personal care services based on time, price, and convenience
- Wants to combine multiple services in one visit instead of making separate appointments
- Cares about how long the full appointment will take
- Wants to compare service options before booking
- Prefers a clear and predictable step-by-step mobile flow
- Sometimes wants a specific stylist for colour services
- Main goal is to book a hair colour, haircut, and treatment appointment in one smooth session

Needs

- Clear categories for colour, cut, and treatment
- Easy multi-service booking in one flow
- Visible total price and duration before confirmation
- Option to choose a stylist or no preference
- Simple review and appointment management on mobile

Obstacles

- Long service lists are hard to scan
- Hard to tell which colour service is right
- Multi-service availability can be unclear
- Full dates or changing schedules make planning difficult
- Policies may appear too late in the flow

Desires

- Book colour, cut, and treatment in one appointment
- Finish booking quickly without calling
- Feel confident before confirming
- Save information for faster future bookings
- Get clear feedback when something is unavailable

3 Main Tasks

Main Tasks / Flows

Flow 1: New client books a hair colour, haircut, and treatment appointment
Emily is a new client who wants to book multiple salon services in one visit. She first creates a basic profile, then selects hair colour, haircut, and treatment services, chooses a stylist or no preference, and selects an available date and time. The flow ends with a review screen that shows the full appointment details, total duration, total price, and cancellation policy before confirmation.

Flow 2: Returning client reschedules an upcoming appointment on mobile
A returning client opens the app to manage an existing booking. The user views the appointment details, selects a reschedule option, and chooses a new available date and time. The flow ends with an updated confirmation screen that clearly shows the revised appointment details.

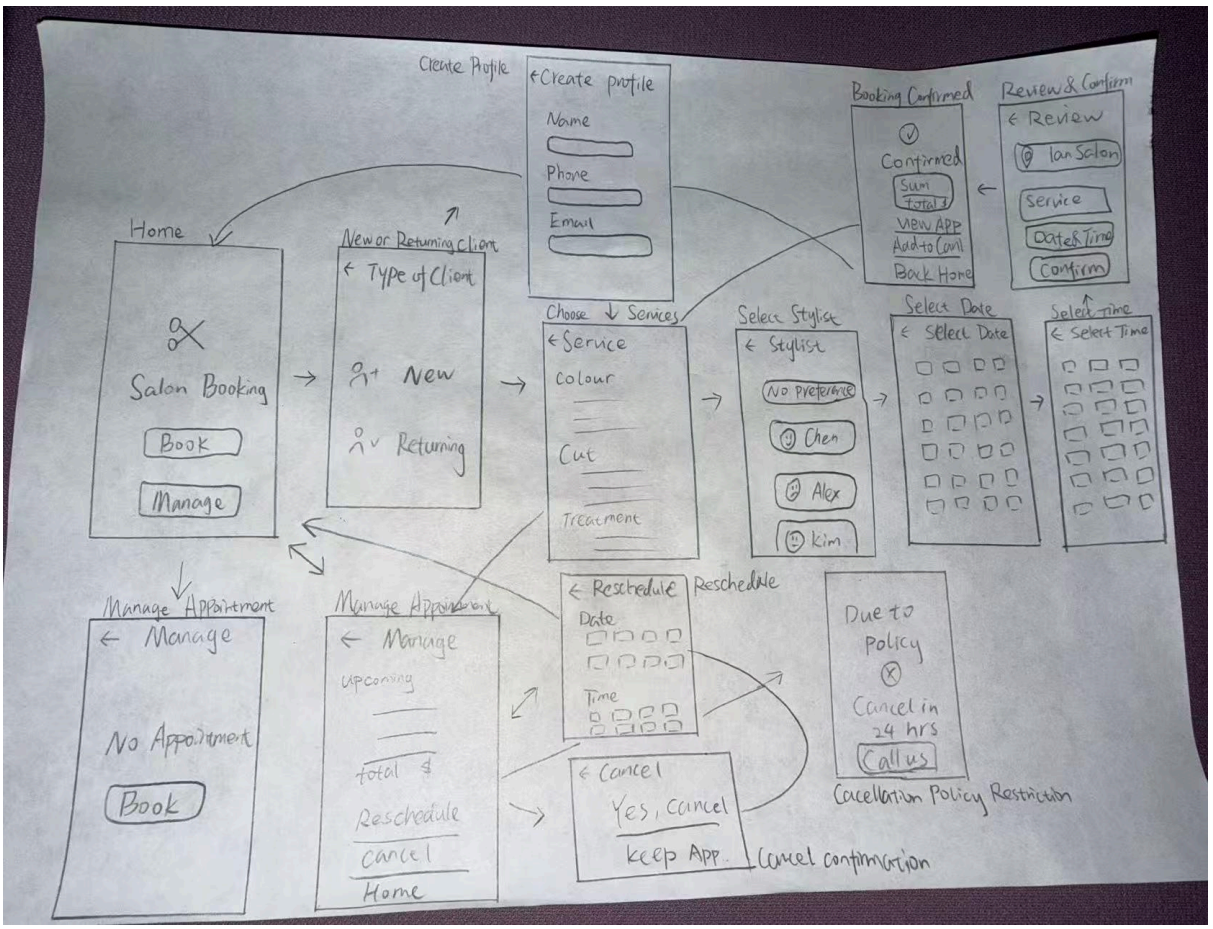
Flow 3: Returning client cancels an appointment on mobile
A returning client decides they can no longer attend an upcoming appointment. The user opens the appointment details, selects cancel appointment, reviews the cancellation warning or policy information, and confirms the action. The flow ends with clear feedback showing whether the cancellation was successful.

Edge Cases

Edge Case 1: Selected date is fully booked
During Flow 1, the user may choose a date with no remaining availability. Instead of ending the process, the system shows that the date is fully booked and offers the next available date.

Edge Case 2: Cancellation is not allowed within the policy window
During Flow 3, the user may try to cancel too close to the appointment time. In this case, the system explains that online cancellation is no longer available and shows the salon policy along with the next step.

Low-Fidelity Sketches



Low-fidelity prototype

This low-fidelity prototype maps the main booking and appointment management flows for the salon system. It was used to plan the structure of the interface before building the high-fidelity prototype. The main happy path shows how a new client creates a profile, selects multiple services, chooses a stylist, selects a date and time, reviews the booking, and confirms the appointment. Alternative flows also show appointment management, rescheduling, normal cancellation, and cancellation restriction within 24 hours.

Main happy path

Home → New or Returning Client → Create Profile → Choose Services → Select Stylist → Select Date → Select Time → Review and Confirm → Booking Confirmed

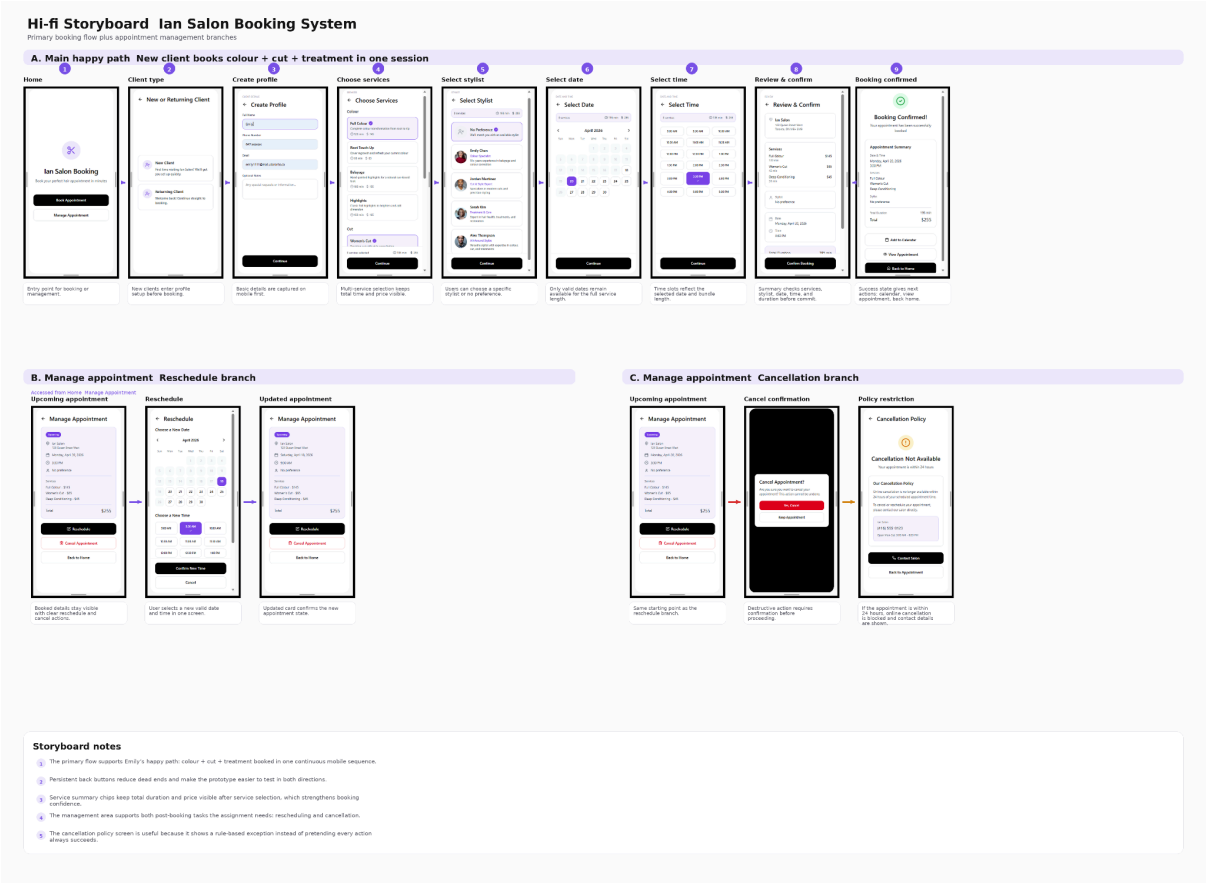
Alternative flows

Home → Manage Appointment → Reschedule

Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancel Confirmation

Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancellation Policy Restriction

High-Fidelity Sequential Storyboard



https://drive.google.com/file/d/1fvknM9ZC6MB-Xh4702nuvkUUx1eYkTmj/view?usp=sharing

High-fidelity storyboard

This high-fidelity storyboard shows the final booking and appointment management flow for the Ian Salon Booking system. The main happy path shows how a user starts from the home screen, identifies as a new or returning client, creates a profile if needed, selects services, chooses a stylist, picks a date and time, reviews the booking, and confirms the appointment. Alternative flows show how users can manage an existing appointment by rescheduling it, cancelling it through a confirmation dialog, or encountering a cancellation policy restriction when the appointment is within 24 hours. The storyboard uses clear screen sequencing, arrows, and interface states to show how the system supports both the main booking flow and key edge cases.

Main happy path

Home → New or Returning Client → Create Profile → Choose Services → Select Stylist → Select Date → Select Time → Review and Confirm → Booking Confirmed

Alternative flows

Home → Manage Appointment → Reschedule

Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancel Confirmation

Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancellation Policy Restriction

Clickable Prototype Link

https://schema-exact-26450370.figma.site

Evidence of Iterative Feedback

This prototype was developed through repeated low-fidelity sketching, screen-by-screen refinement in Figma AI, and walkthrough testing of the clickable flow. The main goal of each revision was to make the booking process clear for a user like Emily, who wants to book colour, cut, and treatment in one appointment without confusion.

1. Early structure and flow planning

The first stage focused on mapping the full system at a low-fidelity level. This helped define the main happy path from home to booking confirmation, while also identifying alternative flows for managing an appointment, rescheduling, cancelling, and handling cancellation restrictions. Building the low-fidelity version first made it easier to check whether the system logic was complete before focusing on visual polish.

2. Navigation and flow clarity

An early issue in the high-fidelity prototype was weak backward navigation. Some screens did not clearly support returning to the previous step, which made the booking path feel rigid. To fix this, back buttons were added across subpages, and the booking flow was reorganized into a clearer step-by-step sequence. Step labels such as Step 1 of 5 were also added to improve orientation and show progress.

3. Better support for multi-service booking

Because the persona's main goal is to book multiple services in one session, the service selection screen was revised to better support combined booking. The interface now groups services into colour, cut, and treatment categories and shows time and price on each option. A running summary of selected services, total duration, and total cost was then carried into later screens such as stylist, date, and time selection. This change made the impact of each service choice more visible throughout the process.

4. Stronger appointment management states

Another important revision was separating different management states. The system now includes both a no appointment found screen and a manage appointment screen for users with an existing booking. This improves clarity because the system responds differently depending on whether the user already has an appointment. The manage screen was also updated to show core booking details, total cost, and clear actions for rescheduling or cancelling.

5. Addition of missing edge cases

During walkthrough testing, it became clear that the flow needed to handle cancellation restrictions more explicitly. A standard cancellation confirmation alone was not enough. A separate cancellation policy restriction screen was added for cases where the appointment is within 24 hours. This screen explains why online cancellation is unavailable and directs the user to contact the salon. Adding this branch made the prototype feel more realistic and complete.

6. Visual hierarchy and consistency improvements

Later iterations focused on consistency across screens. Primary actions were standardized as black buttons, selected states were marked with purple accents, destructive actions used red, and success feedback used green. Section labels, cards, spacing, and summary blocks were also made more consistent. These changes improved readability and helped the interface feel like one connected system rather than a set of separate screens.

Overall, the iterative process moved the project from a rough flow diagram to a more complete mobile booking system. Each revision was based on checking whether the user could move through the process smoothly, understand what was selected, recover from mistakes, and manage the appointment after booking.

Design Specifications

This project is a mobile salon booking system designed for smartphone use in portrait orientation. The interface supports three main tasks: booking a new appointment, managing an existing appointment, and changing or cancelling an appointment. The system is designed around a user who wants to combine multiple services in one visit and complete the process quickly on a phone.

Platform and interaction context

The prototype is designed as a mobile-first interface for touch interaction. It assumes short, task-focused use in everyday settings such as commuting, between classes, or during work breaks. The user interacts mainly through tapping, scrolling, and entering short text fields. The design prioritizes simple decisions, visible progress, and low cognitive load.

Primary task flow

The main booking path is:
Home → New or Returning Client → Create Profile → Choose Services → Select Stylist → Select Date → Select Time → Review and Confirm → Booking Confirmed

The system also supports alternative flows:
Home → Manage Appointment → Reschedule
Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancel Confirmation
Home → Manage Appointment → Cancel Appointment → Cancellation Policy Restriction

Core input and output

Inputs include text entry for name, phone number, email, and optional notes, plus tap-based selection for services, stylist, date, and time. Outputs include service summaries, duration and price totals, appointment details, confirmation feedback, and policy messages when actions are restricted.

Information structure

The booking system is organized into clear sections that match the user's mental model of the task:

- profile creation

- service selection
- stylist selection
- date selection
- time selection
- review and confirmation
- appointment management

Service options are grouped into colour, cut, and treatment categories. Each service card includes a short description, duration, and price. Later screens preserve a summary of the selected services so the user does not have to remember earlier choices.

Visual design system

The interface uses a clean, card-based layout with a light background and strong contrast for key actions. Primary buttons are black with white text. Selected states and secondary emphasis use purple accents. Destructive actions such as cancellation use red. Success feedback uses green, and warning or policy restriction states use an amber tone. Approximate key colours used in the interface are:

- Primary accent purple: #7943E8
- Light purple background: #F0ECFC
- Black: #000000
- White: #FFFFFF
- Destructive red: #DC0019
- Success green: #21A647

Typography is a simple sans-serif style with large page titles, smaller section labels, and readable body text. Information is broken into cards to separate tasks and reduce visual overload.

Usability decisions

Several design choices were made to improve usability:

- step labels were added to show progress through the booking flow
- back buttons were added to support easy recovery
- a running summary of selected services, time, and price reduces memory load

- large touch targets support mobile use
- clear button hierarchy distinguishes primary, secondary, and destructive actions
- review and confirmation screens help users check details before final submission
- policy restriction screens explain why an action is unavailable instead of simply blocking the user

Functional constraints

This prototype assumes one active appointment at a time. It does not include payment, account passwords, or live staff-side scheduling logic. The cancellation policy is enforced through interface rules: if the appointment is within 24 hours, online cancellation is disabled and the user is directed to contact the salon. This keeps the scope focused while still representing a realistic service constraint.

Design intent

The overall design goal is to make salon booking feel predictable, fast, and low-stress. Every major screen supports that goal by reducing confusion, keeping important information visible, and helping users complete both booking and appointment management on mobile without needing to call the salon.